

FOOTBALL INTELLIGENCE

Training and Tactics for Soccer Success

ISRAEL TEOLDO, JOSÉ GUILHERME
AND JÚLIO GARGANTA



Football Intelligence

Soccer is the biggest game in the world and has proved to be an unprecedented phenomenon of social impact, inhabiting a prominent place in the daily lives of millions of human beings, a game that has impact even in the most remote places. In an ever-changing world of soccer coaching and tactics, player intelligence has become increasingly important, providing the essential ability to act effectively in a given moment. Therefore, in recent years, the tactical component has been increasingly valued and diffused. Around the world, this dimension of sport performance is being studied and applied by many professionals in the field, from the youth academies all the way through to the professional level.

This book is designed to help those who devote much of their time to improving the quality of the game, by coaching and training highly informed, creative and intelligent players. These coaches devote their time and energy to improve players' and teams' performances. In turn, match analysts, physiotherapists, psychologists, clinicians and the sport science team dedicate themselves to optimize resources that help boost the performance levels of the players, the coaches and the team.

Football Intelligence: Training and Tactics for Soccer Success presents procedures and ideas that, besides assisting in the task of evaluating the tactical performance of soccer players and teams, also allows improving their expression throughout the learning and training phase. This book will be key reading for football coaches and players alike, as well as students and practitioners of sport psychology and performance analysis.

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“This book was written by three genuine superstars of research, theory and practice in top-level soccer. This is a book that refreshes our knowledge with respect to cutting-edge technical and tactical aspects, among others, through the perspective of complexity. No one who is aware of the evolution and development of soccer can fail to read this book written by professors Israel Teoldo, José Guilherme and Júlio Garganta.”

João Paulo Medina, *Sports Executive*

“A compendium of genuine concepts that brings to the light of our discernment a logical and simple comprehension about the game and the training, despite all its complexity. Therefore, it is a book that rebuilds and organizes our way of thinking about the game and the training.”

Ricardo Drubsky, *Coach*

“All the tactical complexity of soccer condensed into an intelligent book, which leads us to an understanding of important concepts, therefore opening new paths for a better preparation and assessment of a soccer team.”

Ney Franco, *Coach*

Football Intelligence

Training and Tactics for Soccer Success

**Israel Teoldo, José Guilherme and
Júlio Garganta**

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This book is dedicated to all those who have devoted much of their time to soccer and to the people involved in it, who help colouring the world and making it a better place to live and get along.



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Foreword

To preface a book by acknowledged experts and researchers in soccer such as Israel Teoldo, Júlio Garganta and José Guilherme is not an easy task.

As Júlio Garganta often says, soccer is played with ideas; well-played soccer is played with good ideas and poor-played soccer, with bad or sometimes no ideas at all. This insight by itself provides us with a taste of the rich content developed by the authors throughout this book.

The passion that distinguishes almost everything that is involved with soccer is something fantastic. However, when the central topic is the game, the subject deserves to be considered with the perception of how complex playing is. That is precisely what the authors do. To the extent that the book offers an immersion into the complexity of the tactical dimension, the more attractive the subject becomes. That reminds me of Constantin Brancusi, when stating that “simplicity is complexity resolved”.

Thus, the great deal is to produce ideas that enable the development of an atmosphere that facilitates the generation of solutions for playing simple, but also with quality and effectiveness. Also, everything is developed within logic—the internal logic of the game, the logic of comprehension. Logic that does not intend to be different, and therefore it is. And it is different because, even in an extremely competitive environment, there is still plenty of space and importance to reflect upon and preserve throughout the entire process, the social, anthropological and philosophical aspects, which are so important when it comes to dealing with people.

The logic is also different because, when coming up with “the game/training back to the players”, implicitly, does not neglect the importance of soccer games practiced in public areas, such as streets, vacant lots, beaches, etc. In this aspect, one of the core ideas refers to the typical freedom of this recreational practices, in which participants are allowed to play the role of the “real owners of the game”, not only by emulating their idols, in an attempt to reproduce their body and gestural expressions, but also to do so in a scenario of endless creativity.

Within this environment, children and teenagers used to learn how to play the game through playing, as they picked up its spirit and played every possible role, thus developing their motor and coordinative skills, as well as their cognitive,

perceptual, attentional and decision-making aspects. All this is translated into a “game-specific knowledge”, and is expressed in a natural, spontaneous, ludic and creative manner, becoming captivating and resulting in the vaunted passion for the “ball game”.

This is how, in an up-to-date context, with great sensibility and within the big picture in which the game is incorporated, the authors manage to convey in this work a deep knowledge regarding the development of the skills necessary to its practice.

Based upon systemic thinking, they show that a team is something different from its players, who cease to be isolated parts to become a unit along with the others and thus acquire a new expression.

By potentializing training and the different forms of assessment, Israel Teoldo, Júlio Garganta and José Guilherme propose a new way to effectively prepare players and specially the team, *raison d'être* of the game itself.

Through the interactions, permeated by intentions (behaviours), players and teams are capable of materializing the ideas originally proposed. Thus, they become capable through the broad repertoire, which is systematically acquired and applied in training sessions. Besides, they are encouraged to reflect upon what to do in the different moments or phases of play, thus being allowed, within certain contexts, to make more appropriate decisions to the different demands and as effectively as possible. Therefore, we understand that “training makes the game, which justifies or validates training” (Júlio Garganta).

These are some of the ingredients that the beloved reader will find in this seminal work about the pedagogy of soccer, written by three of the greatest exponents in this area, and that will certainly make you reflect critically about several aspects of teaching soccer, by confronting traditional and present methods.

Enjoy your reading!

Paulo Autuori
International Brazilian Soccer Coach

Foreword

To preface a book with so many tested theoretical contents about soccer is for me something rather rewarding and odd at the same time. This is because after 40 years of work in Brazil and abroad, I am still regarded, pejoratively, as a theoretical coach. All because I value the game in which the player does not only play but also reads it, thinks it and generates ideas.

I have always believed that our (Brazilian) way of observing and understanding the game was rather subjective. It was enough to observe and analyse the plays of each player, and we had all the indicators we needed to understand the team's performance.

We have got used to think of a team as the sum of individual performances and of areas that are drawn together as a whole. We have managed to get where we are now by developing the technique of our players who, by their exuberance and brilliance, have made us five-time world champions.

Nevertheless, nowadays we begin to understand that the path that will lead us back to victories and world titles goes through a quite accurate adjustment to what this book so cleverly presents us.

The new soccer, in contrast with soccer played three decades ago, shows us that we can no longer “play” without any of the 11 team players, in the different moments of the game: attack, defence and offensive and defensive transitions. And that does not refer to having a player sent-off, but rather a player who is on the field and does not perform collective actions to achieve the goal.

In this context, the authors, PhDs in their activities, show us that it is not enough to play the game, everyone does that, that it is not enough to know what to do during the game, many do that, but, above all, it is necessary to know the reason for every detail of this complex system, which possesses several games within a game (playing at home or away, early or closing moments of the match, early or final stages of a competition, scoring or conceding first, among others).

Therefore, this book allows us to step into the world of objectivity of soccer, providing us with tools that facilitate our work with our smart goal in an accurate way, without, forcibly, neglecting the beauty of the game.

The didactic and evaluative tools presented here enable the anticipation of scenarios and, in view of the content presented, make this a bedside book for the

coaches who want to become winners in a profession not only so cruel and difficult but also honourable and beautiful.

Enjoy your reading!

Renê Simões
International Brazilian Soccer Coach

Foreword

My thoughts on soccer and the concepts I apply bring ideas to a game that prioritizes the synchrony, from all the tactical aspects to the players' technical excellence. The concepts that I usually develop with my players range from the clear definition of their positions according to the game and involve, among other aspects, qualified possession of the ball, in-depth triangulations, aggressive marking and speed in actions of transitional play.

I believe that in order to develop these concepts and maximize the athletic quality of a team we should be prepared for intelligently managing to obtain the full potential of our players in the different game (physical, technical, tactical and emotional) components.

In search of this purpose, this book comes at the right time and with an important mission: to support coaches and soccer practitioners in general, to accumulate knowledge so as to fundamentally enable us to display increasingly more efforts that qualify our game.

The authors of this book alert to the interrelation between the concepts of tactics and strategy, the development of tactics through the model and the principles of play, the creation and occupation of spaces, positioning and movement of players, which I consider key concepts for when we are preparing to play a match. By performing this preparation, we generate a strategy, anticipate potential situations, seek to provide athletes and the team with options of offensive movements and defensive positioning that will allow us to achieve our goals. A well-done and grounded preparation enables us, during the game, to endorse or, if necessary, to rethink the initial strategy, as the game speaks and shows us other routes, which implies that, all of a sudden, we should choose for plan B, tactical alternatives that were also practiced during pre-match.

In one of the chapters within this book, the authors highlight the tactical modelling, which is the expression of what we plan and intend for the game and how we interpret its essence. In order for soccer to be played with ideas, modelling of training and play should provide athletes with conditions to think, to propose the game. Through this organization, we are able to qualify their decision-making and thus have players who are more active than reactive to the game. I say this

because, for me, it is more pleasing to watch athletes and teams that do not display a systematically reactive play.

As a means to examine whether the players understand the concepts I show them, I have been systematically searching for tools to assess, operationalize and guide training according to how I think soccer and how I prefer my teams to behave on the field. I am an apologist for teams that possess creative players, with good technical level (good reception, good passing, etc.) that read the game well, are intense, fast, dynamic, competitive and supportive. Obviously, I am aware that all these qualities are hard to find within the same team, however, the more qualities my team possesses, the closer to excellence in performance and, consequently, of victories we will be.

Particularly, 2014 was a year of professional qualification. I dedicated in my personal and professional life some time to watch, on site, Bayern Munich, Barcelona, Real Madrid, Arsenal, Manchester City, Atletico Madrid matches, among other teams, and to follow decisive matches such as the Champions League and Copa Libertadores finals. In these opportunities I managed to interact with top-level professionals such as Carlos Bianchi and Carlo Ancelotti and to have several interesting conversations, in which I could review and confirm my concepts on soccer. I also used this time to read and study about the (General, Operational, Core and Specific) tactical principles and how to apply them to the training method I adopt, so as to allow my team to play as a proponent of the game. Through the knowledge gained I could think of new and motivating training sessions, which could, among other things, support players' positioning on the field in several situations such as defensive and offensive coverages, development of set pieces in offensive dead ball situations, defenders' positioning and movement in set pieces, team's intra- and inter-lines' organization, and "aggressive" and "fast" transitions of play, such as "lose-and-press" and counter-attacking, among others.

Therefore, in face of the growing importance of the tactical component for quality play—and we could intimately observe this importance during the World Cup matches in Brazil—this excellent book by the trio of professors Israel Teoldo, Guilherme Oliveira and Júlio Garganta comes to convey ideas that allow to enlighten soccer and, as direct promoters of this spectacle, I believe that all of us should enjoy this effect. Thus, I hope you, reader, might enjoy this reading. My technical staff colleagues and I are already doing so!

Enjoy your reading.

Adenor Leonardo Bachi (Tite—Coach of Brazilian National Team)

Adenor Leonardo Bachi (Tite)

Introduction

Soccer has proved to be an unprecedented phenomenon of social impact, inhabiting a prominent place in the daily lives of millions of human beings, a phenomenon that may be witnessed even in the most remote places of the planet.

On the match stage and behind the scenes of practice and training, the demands of specialization are increasingly greater and more refined, which justifies an increased responsibility and a more accurate competence by all those involved.

The players play the game. The coaches devote their time and energy to improve players and teams' performances. In turn, match analysts, physiotherapists, psychologists, clinicians and the remaining staff dedicate themselves to optimize resources that help boosting the performance levels of players, teams, coaches and others.

In this context, practice in youth academies and top-level professional teams has posed continuously different and challenging problems, with respect to the relevance of the training to play according to ideas and playing styles that allow the materialization of these ideas. Therefore, modern training methodologies are incessantly urged to include practices related to representativeness and specificity of the models and conceptions of play, in order to ensure a significant transfer of sport performance, from training to competition, and to make preparation increasingly consistent.

It is clear, therefore, that the progress of soccer depends, more and more, on the need to create and systematize a body of knowledge that supports the evolution of practices. Hence, it seems relevant to study soccer, in its various fields, in order to help understand the constraints that favour or hinder the progress of players, teams and of the game itself. At the same time, it is necessary to spread knowledge, so as to benefit from it.

The authors of this book have devoted a significant part of their academic, professional and personal time to this enthralling team sport and, over the years, have come to realize that there is not only one single "geography of knowledge" in soccer, just as there is no single answer to the questions: How to train? How to play?

Effectively, the richness of soccer seems to lie, largely, in the fact that it can be played, practiced and thought of in plural. Hence we are in favour of neither the

globalization of training methods nor the standardization of playing styles. On the contrary, we acknowledge that the different perspectives, training and forms of expression of teams and players, comprise an important asset, so that this sport never ceases to be an art and, as such, remains very much alive and keeps stirring emotions.

This work is a result of the study, practice and reflection of its authors, always taking soccer playing and training in soccer as mottos, and was conceived with the purpose of spreading and sharing a way of prospecting and evaluating the game of soccer, according to logics and principles. From a conceptual organization, several drills are presented and evaluation procedures are suggested, and may be applied to gather information regarding the tactical performance of players and teams.

It should be said, however, that the systematization of conceptions and knowledge presented here should not be outlined as a prescription. On the contrary, they are intended to also constitute a contribution that challenges other ways to see and understand soccer.

We wish to dedicate this book to all those who admit that the act of training with quality is the most influential condition in the improvement of players, teams and in the positive transformation of soccer.



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Section I

Understanding the Soccer Game and Its Dynamics



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1 Soccer

A Game of Tactical Knowledge

1.1 Tactics as a Complex Dimension

Throughout the years, soccer has been analysed through different perspectives that have emerged due to the use of paradigms that were created by part of the scientific community, which began to apply them to understand the reality of the phenomena (Capra, 1996; Morin, 1991).

Over the last centuries, the evolution of knowledge and expertise was based on paradigms that separated the phenomena or the objects of study so as to understand them in a more simplified manner (Morin, 1991). These approaches not only facilitated countless discoveries and promoted exponential growth in science but also made it clear that the complexity of certain phenomena and fields could not be studied from such angle. That is, they could not be simplified and had to be studied inside the limits of their inherent complexity; otherwise they would cease to exist. Trying to solve this issue, new fields of study, theories and investigation methodologies emerged in the Sixties in a more consistent manner, attempting to understand the phenomena in their complex nature (Benkirane, 2002; Capra, 1996; Morin, 1991; Stacey, 1995).

The attempt to comprehend and understand soccer games is also going through this dichotomy of paradigms. On the one hand the game is split into four dimensions (tactical, technical, physical and psychological), but on the other hand new approaches appear, describing the game as a full and complex creation, in which any attempt of breaking it apart is regarded as a mutilator of its essence. While in the first approach these different dimensions are broken down to the smallest detail, in the second approach, the study of the whole, the dimension or the detail are inseparable from the complexity intrinsic to it.

Given these different approaches, elaborated with the purpose of understanding and acting effectively and efficiently within the game and, consequently, within the training that generates it, we understand that the concept of tactics in soccer should also be considered in light of its own complexity.

In this context, if the definitions of tactics from different authors (Garganta & Oliveira, 1996; Gréhaigne, 1992; Mahlo, 1974; Teodorescu, 1984) point towards the behaviours that the player and/or team assume to deal in a correct way with the problems systematically presented by the game regarding the occupation of

the field, it is reasonable to say that the concept of tactics may be considered as the management (positioning and displacement/movement) of the playing space by players and teams.

This concept is related to what may be observed of the behaviour of players and the team in the field. Thus, we emphasize that this is a simple way to conceive tactics, given that underlying each positioning and displacement/movement there is a complex process that involves multiple aspects of players' cognition—(central and peripheral) perception and memory, information processing, attention/concentration and the (procedural and declarative) knowledge among them—which subsidize a more creative and/or intelligent decision-making from the players and the team, leading to the solution of the problems posed by the game.

Such comprehension of tactics takes this dimension to an emergent process (Frade, 1990; Laughlin, 2008), resulting in the interaction between a combination of factors, ideas and specific knowledge (Guilherme, 2004; Mahlo, 1974) among the different actors of a team: players, coach and the surrounding context (Guilherme, 2004). Therefore, the tactical dimension of a soccer team should be understood as a unique structure distinguished by its non-linear and spiralling complexity and dynamics. In summary, it is about a specific cultural context generated by the interaction of its different actors, which enables the emergence of a collective identity over time.

This idea of the tactical dimension as a unique structure, in which each team uncovers their own measure in a *sui generis* manner, contrasts with the abstract idea through which it is often presented. Thus, when we talk about a team's tactical dimension we do not mean a general concept, but rather a specific one, which contextualizes and gives meaning and consistency to all other dimensions.

In this case, as defined by Gibson (1979), the specificity refers to a qualifying concept of a relation of interaction between variables. These variables represent the specific information of a given context (Laughlin, 2008). As such, the variables are only considered specific if the informational links between them maintain a relation of dependence (Beek, Jacobs, Daffertshofer, & Huys, 2003). Therefore, the tactical dimension assumes in each team a different organism, with its own identity and particularities, which emerge from the relation of complicity with other dimensions. These, however, also exhibit particular characteristics influenced by the specific informational context generated by the respective interactions.

As a consequence of such properties, the technical, physical or psychological dimensions are meaningless without the tactical one to contextualize them, in the same way that the tactical dimension cannot express itself if any of the others is not present. With this statement we do not intend to convey the idea that the tactical dimension is more important than the others, but rather to highlight that it plays the role of generator, catalyst and specific informational coordinator of each team.

This understanding of tactics refers to the interaction of distinct variables: the ideas and specific knowledge of the different actors.

The ideas are related to the direction we give to the way of solving problems. Usually, coaches know the style of play they intend to implement in their teams. They know what they want in the different moments of play, they know what they intend when the team is in offensive or defensive organization or in the respective transitions (defence-attack and attack-defence). These are the ideas conveyed to the players through training, the process of incorporating the play (Maciel, 2011), which drives the paths to be followed by the teams and their respective players. The coaches' ideas function as a guiding light. Therefore, the play that is created is closely related to the ideas transmitted by the coach.

The players' specific knowledge is related to the interaction between their particular tactical understanding and expertise related to distinguishing motor skills applied to the context (Guilherme, 2004). The specific tactical knowledge leads us to the knowledge the player possesses that allows him/her to play, selecting the options that seem appropriate when facing different situations. This one is related to the declarative and procedural knowledge. With respect to both concepts, procedural knowledge is related to the motor skills which ensures the feasibility of the action intended to operationalize the decision (Guilherme, 2004).

When there is an interaction between the player's specific knowledge, and the coach's ideas of play, the outcome is a collective project of dynamic play, simultaneously and paradoxically, predictable and unpredictable.

The predictability emerges from the ideas of play the coach conveys and is structured on a macro level. On the other hand, the unpredictability rises from the interpretation and interaction structured on a micro level that the different players make from those ideas, with their own knowledge, perception and particularities.

Let us make an analogy to better understand and evoke the idea. Say the ideas of play the coach intends to convey are represented by the colour blue. When the idea of this colour is transmitted, it will be interpreted by the players and each one will recognize this blue in a peculiar way, according to their experiences, characteristics, skills, limitations, preferences and emotions. When these different blues expressed by the players interact, the resulting shade of blue that emerges is unpredictable.

Through this analogy we have just presented, we intend to demonstrate that the predictability is the understanding that the interaction between the coach's ideas and the players' specific knowledge will be represented by the colour blue, and not by red, green or yellow. However, the shade of blue that will rise from every interaction is unknown to us. This is the unpredictability, the shade of blue, on the macro level, and the different players' shades, on the micro level.

The combination of the coaches' ideas, the respective interpretation by the players and the resulting rebuilding of these ideas through the training process is what enables the players to continuously find new individual and collective paths.

At this point, we intend to highlight that tactic is a complex dimension related to the team's identity and also to the operational process of building this identity. Next we will seek to understand the tactical evolution that game and the player had over time.

1.2 The Paths Taken by Tactics

From its origins to the present day, soccer has been through different phases, characterized by equally distinct demonstrations of play (Guilherme, 2004). These phases grant understanding of the evolution of the game, the player and, at the same time, of the concept of tactics.

As mentioned earlier, the current definition of tactics refers to the behaviours the player and/or the team performs to solve the problems that arise from the game. We also verified that the patterns of these behaviours come from the interaction between various levels, specifically the coaches' ideas and the players' specific knowledge. Thus, we understand tactics as a concept from which emerges a particular and specific informational context that is gradually built and recreated in a spiralling way, as its actors interact in training and matches.

Therefore, we are aware that the onset of tactics in the soccer game is in the origin of the game itself, regardless of the completely different nuances currently observed.

1.3 The Game Begins, Tactics Emerge

The emancipation of soccer as a game happened at the occasion of its institutionalization through The Football Association, in 1863, in England. However, its practice as a recognized sport started in the early years of this century.

The first known rules were proposed in 1815 by the Eton College. However, it was only in 1848 in Cambridge, in a meeting between the most prestigious Universities at the time, that the first standardized rules were created, strongly influenced by rugby (Sebastián, 1996). The particularities highlighted, such as the prohibition of passing the ball to a more advanced teammate, which would be considered offside, constrained the progression of the team and the players in the field, thus determining the characteristics of the game and player at that time (Castelo, 1996). The solution found to overcome this issue was the progression through individual actions. The player in possession of the ball would move forward trying to dribble all opponents that appeared and, if successful, would shoot at goal. However, if any of the opponents took away the ball, he/she would be the one to perform the same actions of progression and dribble. The teammates of the player leading the progression were concerned about supporting him/her and, if he/she lost possession of the ball, they would try to recover it and start a new action of dribbling penetration. The players of the opposite team would try to prevent this advancement, and when they gained the ball, they would try to advance themselves through dribble. Because of these characteristics, this period of soccer was mentioned to as the dribbler's period (Castelo, 1996). The arrangement of the players on the field employed at the time consisted of one goalkeeper, one defender and nine forwards (1-1-9) (Figure 1.1). This solution turned the game into a set of individualized actions with little collective meaning.

After the foundation of The Football Association in 1863 there was an attempt to permanently emancipate soccer from rugby. This effort enabled the introduction

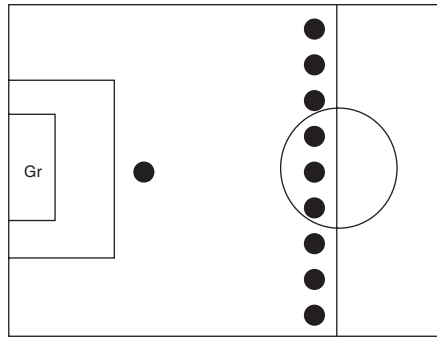


Figure 1.1 Representation of the arrangement of the players on the field: (1–1–9) one goal-keeper, one defender and nine forwards

Source: Guilherme (2004)

of changes to the rules in 1866, which was decisive for the evolution and the path that the game started to follow.

The most relevant adjustment, among many, was the modification in the offside rule. A player would then be considered offside only if he/she received the ball without having at least three opponents between himself/herself and the opposite goal line. This alteration made forward passes possible, thus progressively turning soccer from a game of essentially individual features into a game of collective ones (Gréhaigne, 1992).

With the purpose of creating new solutions to the possibilities and characteristics the game began to present, the arrangements of the players started to change. There was a decrease in the number of forwards and an increase in the number of players with defensive and organizational tasks, that is the concern gradually shifted to lessen the imbalance between the number of players in defence and attack (Figure 1.2) (Castelo, 1996).

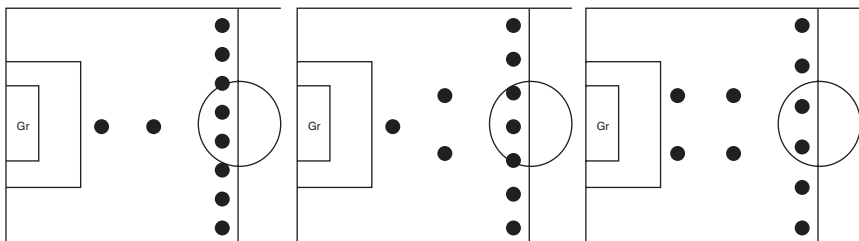


Figure 1.2 Representation of the different arrangements of the players on the field: (1-1-1-8) one goalkeeper, one defender, one midfielder and eight forwards; (1-1-2-7) one goalkeeper, one defender, two midfielders and seven forwards; (1-2-2-6) one goalkeeper, two defenders, two midfielders and six forwards *Source:* Guilherme (2004)

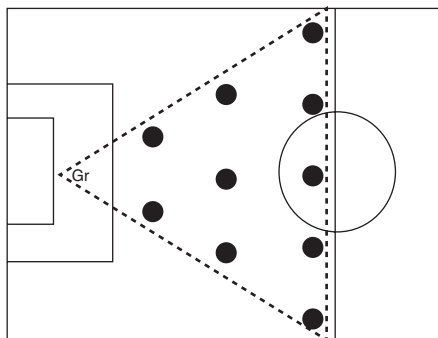


Figure 1.3 Representation of the “Classical System” or “Pyramid”: (1-2-3-5) one goalkeeper, two defenders, three midfielders and five forwards

Source: Guilherme (2004)

These changes were progressive for around 20 years, until 1884, when as a consequence of the evolution that had been observed there came which was considered the first soccer system, the “Classical System” or “Pyramid” (Figure 1.3). This system was organized with players arranged in: one goalkeeper, two defenders, three midfielders and five forwards (1-2-3-5). It was considered the first soccer system because, for the first time, the three sectors of the team were taken into account: defence, midfield and attack, allowing a certain balance between offensive and defensive actions (Castelo, 1996; Mendes, 1979).

In comparison with the game played in previous decades, the meaning of the game had definitively changed. Due to the generalized possibility of passing, the game was no longer a set of individual actions of dribbling progression, but rather a more collective one.

This stage of adaptation and evolution (in)to a game with different, more collective characteristics, lasted around 50 years. Another change in the offside rule, proposed in 1925, reduced for two the number of opponents the attacker were allowed to have between himself/herself and the opposite goal line when he/she received the ball, led the game to a considerable evolution. From that point forwards, the doors to the development of tactics were also opened, since the ideas for solving problems of the game started to diversify. As an example of the alterations observed then, the centre-backs who previously played in projection (one in front and the other behind) started to play in line to benefit from the offside rule. Those players positioned up the field, by the side corridors, known as wingers, progressed to play close to the line of the centre-backs, thus shaping the “W” of notorious systems, which have been very successful since the 1930s.

Because of the emergence of three new coaches, from three different countries, who revolutionized the characteristics of soccer and influenced the following generations, that decade was considered, in turn, quite rich. Herbert Chapman

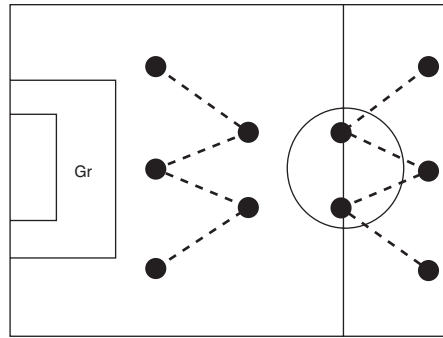


Figure 1.4 Representation of Herbert Chapman's "WM System"

Source: Guilherme (2004)

appeared in England, while Italy and Austria saw the rise of Vittorio Pozzo and Hugo Meisl, respectively. In 1932, Herbert Chapman, Arsenal's coach, developed a new playing "system" called "WM" (Figure 1.4). This "system" became revolutionary because it provided, for the first time, a numerical balance between defenders and forwards and, as a result, individual defence appears as a collective concern (Sebastián, 1996). If we project the letters that make the acronym for this system among teams, we will notice that the "W" (attack) projected on the "M" (defence) provides the exact fit of the marking for each player: the centre-back marking the centre forward, the full-backs marking the two midfielders and the defensive midfielder marking the attacking midfielder. In addition, this system enabled a balanced occupation, for that time, of all playing spaces: defence, mid-field and attack. These positional characteristics brought out a more collective game compared to the one practiced up to that point, and it was from that time on that the tactical dimension started being acknowledged in the characteristics and qualities the game exhibited (Guilherme, 2004).

The "WM system", also known as "magic square" due to the square-shaped positioning of the four midfield players, was of paramount importance for the evolution of the characteristics of the game and the players. The game began to show a more collective meaning (Castelo, 1996), while the player became an integral part of a group with previously established tasks and objectives, in which the final result was not the sum of all players' roles, but rather of the relations they took on. For the first time, there was an idea of an organized team, both collectively and individually (Guilherme, 2004).

Vittorio Pozzo, coach of the Italian National Team crowned World Champions in 1934 and 1938, and gold medallist at the Olympic Games in Berlin, in 1936, was also a very important coach at that time, due to the titles won and his ideas of play. Pozzo's ideas of play were based on off-ball play and on the preparation he demanded from the team. He wanted the team to display a very rigorous and

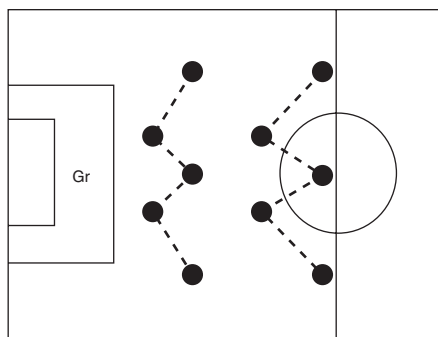


Figure 1.5 Representation of Vittorio Pozzo's "WW System"

Source: Guilherme (2004)

safe defensive organization, with the purpose of regaining possession and counter attack, through a fast and in-depth play. He was the precursor of counter attacking and positional shifts between forwards. The playing "system" displayed was the so-called WW (Figure 1.5), an adaptation of the "classical system": five defenders, two midfielders and three forwards. With respect to team conditioning, due to the influence of the military dictatorship that ruled the country at the time, he imposed a quite demanding and rigorous physical and psychological preparation, as he understood this was the path to success (Sebastián, 1996).

Hugo Meisl, coach of the Austrian National Team and creator of the so-called *Wunderteam*, dazzled the entire Europe between 1931 and 1935 with the quality of his game. Meisl gathered the renowned technique of the Austrian players and his new ideas of play that were revolutionary at the time and that inspired the following generations. In defensive terms they were the first team to collectively constrain their opponents. It was not only the players with defensive tasks who performed it but also those in the offensive, thus giving rise to the ideas of collective defensive organization and pressing. In offensive terms, he demanded great mobility from all players, required players to constantly shift positions in order to create additional problems to the opponents, and also expected the players with defensive tasks to be involved in the offensive ones (Sebastián, 1996).

These ideas, which then were completely revolutionary and performed by players with great technique, allowed for the soccer game to be played as never seen before. The structure employed by Meisl was an adaptation of the "classical system" with some alterations that had the purpose of creating balance between all three sectors and a rational occupation of the playing space (Figure 1.6).

The *Wunderteam* was considered back then the ultimate expression of attacking soccer (Márcio et al., 1992; Sebastián, 1996). Its continuity was not possible due to the death of its creator in 1937, and because its players were involved in the war during several years. For these reasons Meisl's ideas were neglected at the time,

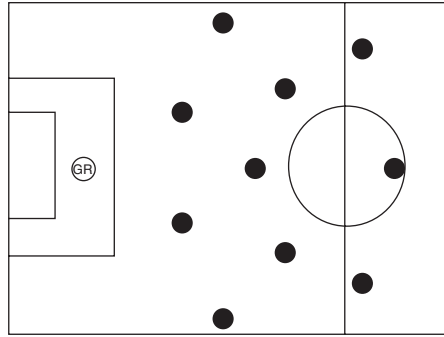


Figure 1.6 Representation of Hugo Meisl's "System"

Source: Guilherme (2004)

maybe because they were far too evolved. Nevertheless, they later inspired several coaches who were also very important for the evolution of the game.

The importance of all three coaches mentioned was decisive due to the ideas introduced, the paths that they opened and, consequently, the ideological versatility that soccer began to exhibit, that is for the first time ever, the relevance of the tactical dimension started taking shape.

The predominance of the "WM" system lasted until the early 1950s, more precisely November, 1953, when England was beaten at home by Hungary 6–3 and again, after a few months, in 1954, in Hungary, 7–1. During the 20 years within this period, some variations of the "WM" emerged, always with the purpose of improving it. However, the true changes only occurred in the 1950s, with the Hungarian and Brazilian National Teams (Sebastián, 1996).

The Hungarian team, coached by Gustav Sebes, featured a group of players of great technical quality, but it was the tactical characteristics that made it different and were responsible for their achievements (Mendes, 1979). The key aspect of the Hungarian team was the dynamics the players and, as a result, the team were able to impose to their offensive game. However, another element displayed was the distinctive positional organization of the players when defending and attacking (Figure 1.7). This change brought several problems to their opponents, due to the static positional approach that existed at the time.

From this point forward, the dynamics, that is the players' and team's mobility with and without the ball proved to be key aspects of the game. It was the return of a more incisive and definitive version of Hugo Meisl's ideas.

The Brazilian team was also decisive within this period due to the new systems it displayed. At first, the "1-4-2-4", (one goalkeeper, four defenders, two midfielders and four forwards), in 1958 and, later, in 1962 the "1-4-3-3" (one goalkeeper, four defenders, three midfielders and three forwards), the latter because it adapted to the players' skills and characteristics (Figure 1.8).

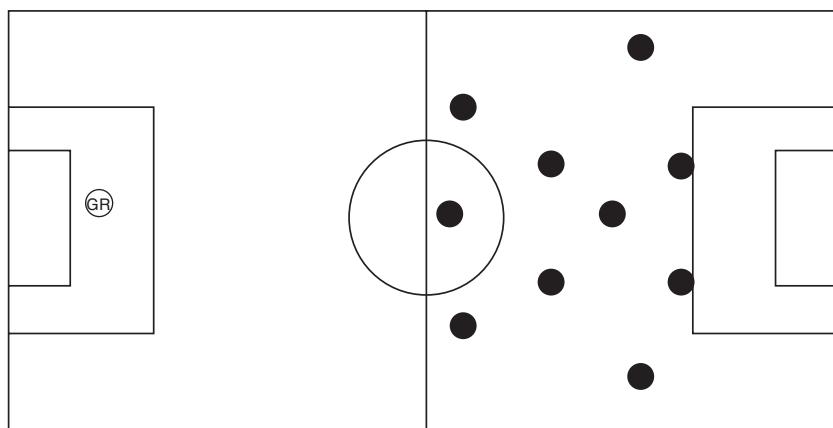
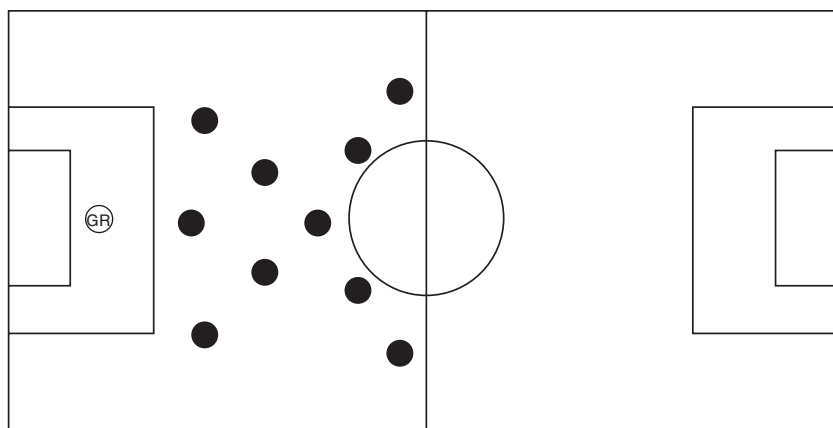


Figure 1.7 Representation of Gustav Sebes' "System", with the positioning of the players when defending and attacking

Source: Guilherme (2004)

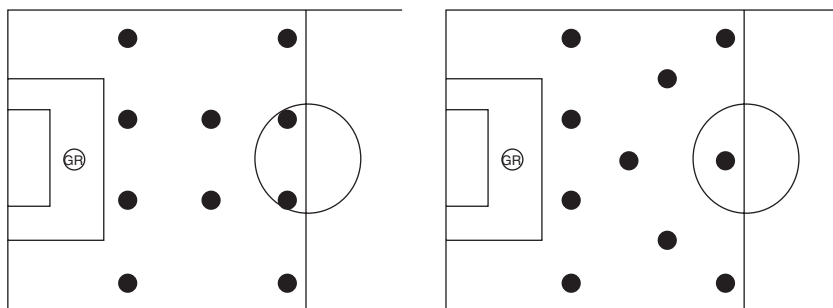


Figure 1.8 Representation of the 1-4-2-4 and 1-4-3-3 "Systems" used by the Brazilian Team in the 1958 and 1962 World Cups, respectively

Source: Guilherme (2004)

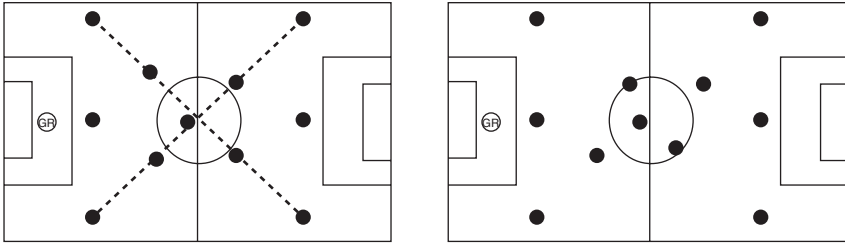


Figure 1.9 X Diagonal of the “WM” and asymmetric “WM” systems, respectively

Source: Guilherme (2004)

The former (1-4-2-4) system was the consequence of the evolution of some years of experiences and adaptations of South American soccer. After the application of the “WM” and “WW” systems in Brazil, mainly in the Flamengo and Fluminense teams during the 1930s and 1940s, alternatives for the expression of the game appeared, slowly displaying the essence of Brazilian soccer (Parreira, 2005).

The first change ever recorded was from the X diagonal of the “WM” System to the asymmetric “WM” (see Figure 1.9), causing one of the midfielders to be pushed forward and the other to be pulled back. Thus, two new functions emerged in soccer: attacking midfielder and centre-forward.

Because the centre-forward often penetrated the penalty box unmarked, forcing the centre-back to divide his attention between him/her and the target man, the fourth defender emerged to mark him/her. Besides, the freedom granted to the full-backs to progress to the offensive half made the defensive coverage of the space vacated by them essential to preserve defensive balance. As a result came the 1-4-2-4, a winning system used by the Brazilian Team during the 1958 World Cup, in Sweden.

Conversely, the 1-4-3-3 system was an evolution of the former caused by some organizational and functional adjustments to the players’ characteristics and skills. This innovative system also allowed Brazil to win the 1962 World Cup, in Chile.

The essential characteristics of these systems were: the balance between the defensive and offensive play, which allowed for an easy and rapid turn from a strong defence into a strong attack and vice versa; a dynamics of team and players which allowed them to generate defensive and offensive edge within the area where the ball was being played; and, lastly, the acknowledgement of the physical dimension as core aspect of this playing style. Both systems were successful at that time, because at first they encouraged by the proposed dynamics that did not exist until then, and also because its demands required of the midfielders who often took part in the defensive and offensive actions of the team (Castelo, 1996; Mendes, 1979; Sebastián, 1996).

Thereafter, the physical dimension started being permanently recognized as decisive for the evolution of the game (Castelo, 1996; Mendes, 1979; Sebastián, 1996).

In spite of the importance of this recognition, it has not always been interpreted with the intention of protecting the essence of the game and, as a consequence, its qualitative evolution. Since the different dimensions of the game were not acknowledged by most of the sports people in its complex uniqueness, there was the interpretation of the possibility of splitting them. If in some cases, as we will refer to later, this fact was not evidenced as a limitation for the evolution of the game and the player, in others, it was found that the direction through which it went led the game to winding paths, in which the quality of the play and the players was even up.

One of the most crucial examples of this line of reasoning was the 1966 World Cup, held in England. The champion and runner-up, England and Germany, respectively, were distinguished as the greatest exponents of what was known at the time as the “physical style”. This style of play was distinguished by the supremacy of the physical dimension above all others. The players would run a lot and often went to the challenges with great vigour. Many of the technical and puny players were replaced by the strong, tall and robust ones. The game was described as ugly and violent due to the excessive number of dangerous fouls, lacking technical quality and artless, driven by the absence of skills and creativity displayed by the players (Mendes, 1979).

This style of play, adopted by many European countries and, consequently, important teams after the 1960s, was the answer to the recognition of the need of increased playing dynamics. This challenge was introduced by Gustav Sebes, in the 1950s, and by the Brazilian National teams in 1958 and 1962, though with completely distinct nuances, since, as we mentioned, the dynamics of the teams emerged from the creative and innovative ideas of play presented and from the technical skills of the different players.

Yet, the continuity and evolution of the ideas patented by the Brazilian team in South America and the resurgence in Europe of innovative ideas of play, proposed by the Dutch National team and by Ajax, through the coaches Rinus Michels and Stephan Kovacs, were crucial for generating alternatives to the physical style that had been established in the Old Continent.

Rinus Michels, Ajax’s and future Netherlands’ coach, created an idea of play that would be called “Total Football”. The characteristics that supported this idea elected the technical skills and players’ freedom and intelligence as the most important values of expression (Cruyff, 2002). Passing, constant mobility of the forwards without the ball, continuous support to the player in possession of the ball, versatility of tasks, control of the pace of play, with accelerations, decelerations or breaks generating adaptation problems for the opponents, and the superior technical skills of the different players, supported by the physical dimension, were regarded as basic fundamentals for the offensive play. The reduction of the playing space, thus approximating the areas both in width and length and packing the team, the permanent search for recovering possession in every zone of the field and pressing the player in possession of the ball also supported by good physical strength were the characteristics of the defensive play (Cruyff, 2002; Mendes, 1979; Olivares, 1978; Sebastián, 1996).

According to what we have just mentioned, the late 1960s and the 1970s saw the rise of distinct ideas about the game. These ideas came from the same concern: the need for greater dynamics of play. However, taking into account the main concerns of each to solve the problem, the game began evidencing distinct forms of expression, which, in a simplified manner, may be named “technical-tactical” and “tactical-physical” (Guilherme, 2004).

The “technical-tactical” form, mainly displayed by the Dutch, Brazilian and Argentinian national teams, as well as some domestic teams of these countries, was characterized by a playing style essentially based on the tactical and technical dimensions. The physical dimension also played an important role, but only as a support to the others rather than as a generator of the process. This style of play was expressed in different ways, but focused on the qualitative relation between the offensive and defensive processes and, above all, on their connection with the players’ technical skills. Technique does not appear constrained, but it is rather a conditioning factor. It interacts with the tactical dimension to generate a more qualitative play, which, in consequence, compels the player to create new paths to respond to the ever-growing demands the game begins to exhibit. There is an evolutionary process of spiralling interaction between the game and the player (Guilherme, 2004).

The “tactical-physical” form, exhibited by the English, German, Italian and Spanish national teams, among others, was characterized by a playing style based on the tactical and physical dimensions. Technique emerges from the need of solving problems in the game, but with a secondary importance in relation to and constrained by the other dimensions. For these reasons, in many teams over the years players were selected not according to technical superiority, but to tactical characteristics based on discipline, organizational capabilities and superior physical skills. This style of play can also manifest in different ways: more offensive or more defensive, but always strongly linked to the tactical and physical dimensions.

From the late 1960s up to present days, there has been an ongoing battle between these two styles of play. In some periods, a more “tactical-physical” style has dominated. Some of the highlights of this style were the 1966 World Cup, won by England, the 1982 World Cup, won by Italy and the 1990 World Cup, won by Germany.

In other periods, it was the more “technical-tactical” style that prevailed, particularly when supported by technically evolved players, and when those skills work in favour of the team. Some examples of this style are the Brazilian teams of 1958 and 1962, the Netherlands in 1974, Brazil in 1982, Argentina in 1986 and the current Spanish team. At club level, some European teams were also noteworthy: Rinus Michels’ and Stephan Kovacs’ Ajax of the early 1970s, Arrigo Sacchi’s Milan of the late 1980s, Johan Cruyff’s Barcelona of the early 1990s and, more recently, Pep Guardiola’s Barcelona, Bayern München and Manchester City are some clear examples.

Despite this evident dichotomy in understanding soccer, it was what, over the years, provided moments of clear evolution of the game and the player: The game

because of the new ideas that coaches proposed when facing the problems that arose, especially regarding gradual decrease of playing time and space. The player because he/she not only interpreted the new ideas presented but also reinvented them, at both tactical and physical dimensions, propelling the game to ever more elaborate levels.

According to what we have just observed, the evolution that the game has undergone over the years has different aspects, though it always aimed at solving tactical problems that emerged.

The first period was defined by the emancipation and identification of soccer as a sport with its own characteristics: the creation and restructuring of rules allowed the change from a game with mainly individual expressions into a collective one.

The second was defined by the implementation and evolution of the “playing systems” and by the appearance of players with great technical skills who responded to tactical evolutions, promoting and propelling them to even more advanced levels. The logic that underpinned the effort to solve the evidenced tactical problems was the continuous attempt to balance the power between attack and defence. Some did so by favouring offensive characteristics, while others the defensive ones. Both ways succeeded, but the most exciting were those who focused on the offensive characteristics, supported by the superior technical skills of their players.

The third period came from the acknowledgement of the need to increase the dynamics of the game. The paths to the achievement of these goals diverged. On one side were the advocates of a more “tactical-physical” style, while the ones who preferred a more “technical-tactical” one stood on the opposite side, with mixed expressions in between. The consequence of this significant and permanent increase of “dynamics” reflected in the constant reduction of space and time, thus constraining the teams’ and players’ defensive and offensive play.

Currently, the teams wield their collective and individual competencies through their ideas and respective qualities. While defending, they try to constrain space and time more and better. When attacking, they try to create space and time to better decide and act, sometimes in high intensity, other times with a rhythmic variability with the purpose of limiting the opponents’ adaptations. Thus, the styles of play are distinct. We are being increasingly exposed to peculiar ideas of play; however, those characterized by the triumphs and aesthetics are the ones based on a game played in collective way, in which the technical excellence and diversity and the intelligence and creativity are acclaimed (Cruyff, 2002; Valdano, 2002).

So that these styles of play can be expressed, we propose the analysis of soccer as a complex game and, therefore, the understanding of the concept of tactics through this perspective. Instead of understanding it as an abstract dimension, appreciate it as a specifying one that promotes the interaction and identification of all other dimensions and, consequently, of the team.

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